



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ville De Marie Academy

School Website: <https://villedemarieacademy.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Ville de Marie Academy AZ 85251 (Scottsdale, AZ) presents a robust classical, Catholic liberal-arts program that is deeply anchored in religious formation, traditional pedagogy, and family partnership. Public-facing materials emphasize a Catholic worldview, formation of character through truth, goodness, and beauty, and a Trivium-informed curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric) taught through Great Books and Socratic dialogue at the upper grades. Liturgy, sacraments, daily prayer, and a strong sense of community are repeatedly foregrounded, together with explicit attention to parental partnership in education. Taken together, these elements indicate a CLASSICAL orientation across all six categories (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations; Purpose and Goal; Curriculum; Pedagogy; Faculty; Parents & Community).

Key insights: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit and pervasive, with Mass, Eucharistic adoration, liturgical life, sacred imagery, and a Catholic anthropology foregrounded in mission and practice. This aligns strongly with the Positive Keywords in the classical lexicon and signals a robust theological framing of education. - The school's stated purpose and goals center on formation, virtue, wisdom, and a Catholic understanding of truth, goodness, and beauty, rather than mere job preparation. This is consistent with the "telos" and paideia language in classic formulations. - The curriculum is explicitly Trivium-based (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with reference to Great Books and the Great Conversation, and a documented high-school emphasis on Socratic dialogue. This maps cleanly to the core curricular markers of classical education. - Pedagogy describes a mix of contemplative/restful and rigorous modes, with upper-level Socratic discourse and rhetoric opportunities, as well as a liturgical/ritual dimension. The public materials provide sufficient evidence of a classical pedagogy in structure and method. - Faculty signals emphasize virtue, leadership, and mentorship roles, and the school evidences senior advisory structures and boards composed of scholars and theologians—consistent with a classical model where teachers function as living witnesses of a virtuous life. - Parents & Community are positioned as co-educators and partners, with explicit statements about parental primacy in education and opportunities for parent formation and visits. This aligns with the classical model's emphasis on a robust home-school partnership.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes fidelity to Catholic magisterium, Ignatian grounding, and formation of wisdom and virtue through pursuit of truth, beauty, and goodness. - Public materials repeatedly frame education within a Catholic framework, including references to Mass, Eucharistic Adoration, and liturgical life. - The Introduction and Mission sections foreground a Catholic worldview and integration of faith with learning (e.g., "Imbued with a Catholic Worldview"; "Sustained by Gospel Witness").

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (example set from the Six Essentials lexicon): truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; Mass; sacred worship; sacramental life; catechesis; imago Dei; Gospel; Catholic worldview. Evidence from mission language and liturgical life supports multiple items in Element 1's positive keyword set. - Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials

(no overt signaling of secularism, relativism, or “values-clarification” tendencies). The materials consistently align with transcendentals and sacred frameworks.

Why this rating - The materials clearly establish a transcendent, objective moral order rooted in Catholic theology and liturgical life. The combination of religious formation, communal worship, and theological integration with curriculum strongly supports a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school’s stated aim is formation of virtue and wisdom, not primarily job preparation; formation and paideia are explicit in the mission. - Public materials describe liberal education and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty, with a telos oriented toward human flourishing and excellence. - The Great Conversation / permanent questions and formation of the whole person are embedded in the mission (e.g., “formation of the whole person,” “true education... directed to man’s last end”).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; liberal education; paideia; the pursuit of true/good/beautiful; human flourishing; telos. - Negative keywords: None evident (no emphasis on workforce-first framing or utilitarian “21st-century skills” language in the public materials).

Why this rating - The materials articulate formation, character, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty as the core aims of education, aligning strongly with classical expectations for purpose and goal.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Explicit triad: grammar, logic, rhetoric, with a clear grade breakdown (Grammar 1–4; Logic 5–8; Rhetoric 9–12) and a framework for dialectic/Socratic engagement. - References to liberal arts, Great Books, and the Great Conversation appear in public materials, with language describing a Catholic liberal-arts curriculum. - The curriculum emphasizes the seven liberal arts and a grounding in theology and classical sources, including Catechesis and sacred text integration.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation; contemplation; wonder; theology; catechesis; classical pedagogy; memory work (narration/recitation). - Negative keywords: None evident (the site does not substitute history with “social studies” or emphasize project-based learning over classical texts).

Why this rating - The curriculum is explicitly structured around the classical Trivium and Great Books emphasis, with clear evidence of liberal-arts sequencing and a Catholic theological framework. This firmly meets CLASSICAL benchmarks for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The pedagogy schema evident from the materials includes Nobler elements: grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, Socratic dialogue, and rhetoric-focused upper-level activities. The presence of Socratic dialogue in the high school, and a memory/recitation dimension in early years, matches classical pedagogy patterns. - The public materials show liturgical, contemplative practices (Mass, Adoration, daily prayers) embedded in school life, aligning with a restful/scholé dimension of pedagogy, as well as contemplative elements. - There is explicit mention of “Socratic Dialogue” in the upper grades and “communication and eloquence” in the rhetoric phase, indicating structured dialectic and rhetorical training.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar; dialectic; narration; recitation; chanting; memory work; liturgical learning; scholé/restful learning; contemplation; rhetoric; debate. - Negative keywords: None evident in the materials (no strong signals of project-based-only or constructivist approaches that would deviate from classical pedagogy).

Why this rating - The pedagogy demonstrates classical characteristics (Socratic dialogue in upper grades, grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, memorization/recitation, and a liturgical/restful dimension), which satisfies CLASSICAL criteria for Teaching Methods.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty is framed as moral exemplars within a community that includes teachers and parents working together toward formation (gospel witness). This aligns with the “living curriculum” concept and “faculty of virtue” language found in classical models. - Public materials reference educators, both parents and teachers, as partners in formation, and describe the advisory/board structure with theologians, philosophers, and pastors (e.g., Rev. Fessio, Alice von Hildebrand). This signals a faculty culture anchored in virtue and intellectual formation. - The presence of an Advisory Board and Board of Trustees with notable scholars and clergy illustrates a faculty/leadership ecosystem that models virtue and intellectual rigor.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum (implied through teachers as moral exemplars and gospel witness); virtue; mentor; master; teacher as guide; faculty of friends; collegial culture; portrait/profile of teacher and student (implied through mission and governance pages). - Negative keywords: None evident (no signs of a purely facilitation model or non-classical staffing language).

Why this rating - The school presents faculty as morally anchored and academically rigorous, supported by a governance/ advisory ecosystem of theologians and scholars. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for the Faculty category.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly identifies parents as the primary educators and emphasizes partnership with them, reflecting classical educational philosophy about the home–school collaboration. - The materials describe parental formation activities, book studies, and opportunities for parents to participate in campus life, as well as open-door policies for visits. This mirrors classical expectations that parents are co-educators and part of a broader educational community. - The Non-Discrimination policy and Catholic identity reflect a community environment aligned with shared formation goals and a welcoming culture for families seeking a Catholic classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teaching; parent formation; readings; classical book clubs; open campus; hospitality; family liturgy alignment. - Negative keywords: None evident (public materials do not depict parents as customers or disconnected from formation).

Why this rating - The public materials consistently present parents as essential collaborators in education, with explicit opportunities for parental formation and engagement, which is a hallmark of classical school community practices.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable for a CLASSICAL overall rating. No category currently requires a needle-moving change to reach CLASSICAL status, based on the evidence available in the public materials.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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